Topic 7 — Mauryan Empire

Covers syllabus (click to expand)

Mauryan Empire · Chandragupta Maurya · Bindusara · Ashoka · then Admin / Officials / Dhamma / Edicts / Arthashastra / Megasthenes (syllabus labels kept, **kings in time-order first**)

Sources baked in: Ashokan epigraphy, Arthashastra, Megasthenes/Strabo, Puranas, Ghatnachakra Maurya Empire, UPPCS Prelims 2018–2025, UKPCS Prelims (Palibothra; Mansehra–Shahbazgarhi; Sudarshan; Sandrokottos; Pranaya; Taxila; Brahmins–Shramanas) **Weight:** ★★★ — RE XII (2022), Agronomai (2020), Dhamma-mahamatras (2024), Vishnu Purana (2023) **Last verified:** September 2026 **Current Affairs:** N/A — static

Books and Writers — Mauryan Age

Book–writer pairs | book → writer | keep play vs statecraft separate

Book / text	Writer / authority	What it is for
Arthashastra (अर्थशास्त्र)	**Kautilya / Chanakya / Vishnugupta** (कौटिल्य / चाणक्य / विष्णुगुप्त)	Sanskrit statecraft; saptanga, officials, courts
Indica	**Megasthenes**	Greek envoy account of Chandragupta's India (lost; known via Strabo, Arrian)
Mudrarakshasa (मुद्राराक्षस)	**Vishakhadatta** (विशाखदत्त)	Sanskrit play on Chandragupta–Chanakya court intrigue
Commentary on *Mudrarakshasa* (मुद्राराक्षस)	**Dhundiraja** (धुन्दिराज)	Later commentary on Vishakhadatta's play
Devichandraguptam (देवीचन्द्रगुप्तम्)	**Vishakhadatta** (विशाखदत्त)	Drama remembered with Gupta-age story (same author; later setting)
Abhisarikavanchitaka (अभिसारिकावंचितक)	**Vishakhadatta** (विशाखदत्त)	Another work attributed to the same dramatist
Dipavamsa	Sinhalese Buddhist chronicle	Third Council at Pataliputra under Ashoka
Mahavamsa	Sinhalese Buddhist chronicle	Same council; Moggaliputta Tissa; Lanka missions
Divyavadana	Buddhist anthology	Taxila revolt under Bindusara; Ashoka as *kumara*
Samantapasadika	**Buddhaghosa**	Ashoka / Avanti tradition in Bindusara's reign

Book / text	Writer / authority	What it is for
Ashokavadana	Buddhist tradition	Ashokan succession legends (use lightly)
Vishnu Purana	Puranic tradition	Maurya genealogy (**UPPCS 2023**)
Manusmriti	Manu tradition	Contrast text: widow remarriage barred; "fallen kshatriyas"
The Prince (*Il Principe*)	**Machiavelli**	European compare-text for *Arthashastra* (not a Mauryan book)
Laghulovada / Rahulovada	Buddhist sutta (not written by Ashoka)	Listed for monks in the **Bhabru** edict

- The *Arthashastra* is **not** the *Mudrarakshasa*.
- The *Indica* is **not** the *Arthashastra*.
- *Devichandraguptam* shares Vishakhadatta's name but its story sits in the **Gupta** (गुप्त) horizon.

> **Logic:** For "author of Indica" the answer is **Megasthenes**. For "author of Arthashastra" the answer is **Kautilya / Chanakya / Vishnugupta**.

7.1 Mauryan Empire

Chandragupta Maurya | c. 322–185 BCE | capital Pataliputra (Ganga–Son)

The Mauryas built the first large pan-North Indian state. Their capital was **Pataliputra** (पाटलिपुत्र) at the Ganga–Son junction.

Origin and Greek names

- Buddhist tradition makes them the **Moriya** clan of **Pipphalivana**.
- The clan's totem is the peacock, and Buddhist texts treat them as kshatriya.
- Brahmanical Puranas give a **low / shudra** origin. That line is a smear after the Nanda overthrow.
- Greek writers remember a humble youth who later topples the Nandas.
- **Plutarch** calls him **Androcottus**.
- **Justin** calls him **Sandrokottos** and remembers a meeting with **Alexander**.
- **William Jones** first equated Sandrokottos with **Chandragupta Maurya** (चंद्रगुप्त मौर्य).

Chanakya and literary sources

- **Chanakya** (चाणक्य) is also called **Kautilya** (कौटिल्य).
- Another name for him is **Vishnugupta**, often treated as his childhood or alternate identity.
- He was a Taxila Brahman. After insult at the Nanda court, he trained Chandragupta.
- His book is the *Arthashastra* (अर्थशास्त्र), a hard statecraft text often compared with Machiavelli's *Prince*.
- The *Mudrarakshasa* (मुद्राराक्षस) of **Vishakhadatta** (विशाखदत्त) is a **play**, not the *Arthashastra*.

- It shows court intrigue under Chandragupta through Malayaketu and Amatya Rakshasa.
- The play calls Chandragupta **Vrishal** and **Kulheen**.
- **Dhundiraja** (धुन्दिराज) wrote a commentary on *Mudrarakshasa*.
- Vishakhadatta's other remembered works are *Devichandraguptam* (देवीचन्द्रगुप्तम्) (a Gupta-age story) and *Abhisarikavanchitaka* (अभिसारिकावंचितक).

King line (overview)

Ruler	Span (approx.)	Must-hold fact
Chandragupta (चंद्रगुप्त)	322–297 BCE	Overthrows **Dhana Nanda**; Greek **Sandrokottos**
Bindusara	297–273 BCE	Greek **Amitraghata / Amitrochates**
Ashoka	Accedes ~272; crowned 268–232 BCE	**Kalinga** (कलिंग), **dhamma** (धम्म), and the edicts
Brihadratha	ends 185 BCE	Killed by **Pushyamitra Shunga (Pushyamitra Sunga)**

- **Kunala** is a legendary blinded heir. He is not a hard epigraphic king.
- **Dasharatha** gifts the **Nagarjuni** caves to the Ajivikas. Tradition often places him in the eastern share.
- **Samprati** is the Jain "second Chandragupta." Tradition often places him in the western and southern share.
- **Salisuka** is a Puranic name only.
- **Devavarman** is a Puranic name only.
- **Satadhanvan** is a Puranic name only.
- The Puranic span of the house is often given as **137 years**.

How to rank the sources

- The hardest evidence is Ashoka's **edicts**.
- Next comes Kautilya's *Arthashastra*.
- Then come Megasthenes' *Indica* fragments.
- The **Vishnu Purana** carries the Maurya genealogy.
- The *Dipavamsa* is a Buddhist chronicle.
- The *Mahavamsa* is a Buddhist chronicle.
- The *Mudrarakshasa* comes last, as a play.
- **James Prinsep** deciphered Brahmi in **1837**.
- The **Maski** edict later proved that **Piyadassi** (प्रियदर्शी) is Ashoka.

Neighbours, pottery, coins, and army size

- Rock Edict **II** names border peoples as **neighbours**, not Mauryan provinces.

Named in RE II	Fact
Chola (चोल)	South neighbour
Pandya	South neighbour
Satiyaputra	South neighbour
Keralaputra	South neighbour
Tamraparni	Sri Lanka; neighbour / mission land, not a province
Yonas	Greek / Yavana neighbours
Kambojas	Northwest neighbours

- **NBPW** continues under the Mauryas. It began in mahajanapada towns, not only under Ashoka.
- **Ring-wells** mark Mauryan settlement layers.
- The coin is the punch-marked **pana / karshapana**. There are no royal portraits on it.
- Pliny gives an army of about **600,000** foot, **30,000** horse, and **9,000** elephants. Treat this as order of size, not a muster roll.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2023, Q29

With reference to the Puranas, which one of the following statements is correct?

1. Information about the Mauryan dynasty is found in the Vishnu Purana.
2. Vayu Purana throws light on the Gupta system of governance.

A. Only 1 B. Only 2 C. Both 1 and 2 D. Neither 1 nor 2

Show answer

Logic: The Vishnu Purana is asked for Maurya genealogy. The Vayu Purana lists Gupta kings; it is not a Gupta administration manual. **Ans: A — Only 1.** The Vishnu Purana carries the Maurya genealogy. The Vayu Purana lists Gupta *kings*; it is not a Gupta *admin* manual.

> **Logic:** Chandragupta Maurya is not Chandragupta II. The empire ends in **185 BCE**, not with Ashoka's death in **232 BCE**.

7.1a Post-Ashoka Decline and Fall (232–185 BCE)

- After Ashoka (**~232 BCE**), weak successors (**Dasharatha, Salisuka, Brihadratha**) followed in Puranic lists.
- Tradition remembers a partition: **Dasharatha** in the east, **Samprati** (Jain patron) in the west/south.
- Provincial governors and frontier pressure weakened central control.
- The last king **Brihadratha** was killed by general **Pushyamitra Shunga (Pushyamitra Sunga)** in **185 BCE**.

- The Mauryan empire lasted about **137 years** (322–185 BCE). Ashoka's death is **not** the empire's end date.

7.2 Chandragupta Maurya

Founder | ~322–297 BCE | Sandrokottos | first king-card, not Ashoka

- He overthrows **Dhana Nanda** with **Chanakya**. The Greek name is **Sandrokottos / Androcottus**. **William Jones** is the peg. **Justin** remembers a meeting with Alexander.
- The Seleucus treaty about **303 BCE** gives **500 elephants**. Megasthenes is sent to his court at **Pataliputra**.
- The **Junagadh** rock of Rudradaman remembers **Pushyagupta** building **Sudarshana lake** in Anarta–Saurashtra under Chandragupta — proof that western India sat inside the Mauryan empire.
- Palace archaeology at Pataliputra points to **Kumrahar** (pillared hall) and **Bulandibagh** (wooden city-wall remains). Greek memory stresses a **wooden** palace and palisade.
- Jain tradition ends him in *sallekhana* with **Bhadrabahu** at **Shravanabelagola**. His son and successor is **Bindusara**.

> **Logic:** This Chandragupta is **322 BCE**. Gupta Chandragupta I is **~320 CE**.

7.3 Bindusara

Son of Chandragupta | ~297–273 BCE | Amitraghata / Amitrochates

- The Greek fact is **Amitrochates** (Sanskrit **Amitraghata**, "slayer of foes"). Jain texts call him **Simhasena**. His mother in Jain tradition is **Durdhara**.
- Envoy **Deimachus** comes from Antiochus I (Strabo). **Dionysius** is remembered as the envoy of Egypt's **Ptolemy II Philadelphus** to the Mauryan court.
- A letter to **Antiochus I** asks for sweet wine, dry figs, and a philosopher. The **philosopher was refused**.
- Tradition gives him an Ajivika lean.
- The *Divyavadana* remembers a **Taxila** (तक्षशिला) revolt; **Ashoka** is posted there as *kumara* to suppress it. Buddhist tradition also places Ashoka as viceroy of **Avanti (Ujjain)** under Bindusara.
- *Samantapasadika* of **Buddhaghosa** remembers Ashoka winning / merging **Avanti** into the Mauryan empire during Bindusara's reign.
- His son and successor is **Ashoka**.

> **Logic:** Bindusara is not the Kalinga king. The Kalinga war is Ashoka.

7.4 Mauryan Administration

Centralised bureaucracy | mantriparishad | salaried amatyas | not a Gupta samanta state

The Mauryan state is a **centralised** empire. Officers are paid. Power does not rest mainly on feudatory **samantas** (सामंत) as in the Gupta age.

King and ministers

- The king is *swami* in the saptanga. He has the final word after consulting ministers.
- Ashoka in Rock Edict VI takes reports **at any hour** through *pativedakas*.
- The cadre is **amatyas / mahamatras**, paid in cash or produce.
- It is a career service, not a closed kshatriya club.
- The top posts are remembered as **18 tirthas**.

Four vidyas (training of a king)

- *Anvikshiki* is philosophy.
- *Trayi* is Veda learning.
- *Varta* is economy.
- *Dandaniti* is polity and punishment.

Two source pictures — keep them separate

- **Kautilya** describes adhyakshas, spies, and taxes.
- **Megasthenes** describes six city boards, six army boards, and seven classes.
- Do not mash the two org-charts into one list.

Army and roads

- The army is *chaturanga* plus a navy under the *navadhyaksha*.
- *Indica* gives a war office of **six** army boards: navy, transport, infantry, cavalry, chariots, and elephants.
- The great road is the **Uttarapatha** (उत्तरापथ) from Taxila to Pataliputra.
- Strabo's agronomoi also set mile-pillars. That road detail is a **trap option**, not the key meaning of Agronomai (revenue / land).

Village to district ladder

- The village has a *gramika* plus elders.
- The *gopa* watches **5–10** villages.
- Next up is the *sthanika*.
- The district is *ahara / vishaya*.
- Kautilya's rural stack in match papers also uses **Samgrahana** (about 10 villages) → **Karvatika** (200) → **Dronamukha** (400) → **Sthaniya** (800).
- Ascending order starts at **Samgrahana**.

Capital and trade officers

- Pataliputra's palisade in *Indica* has **570 towers** and **64 gates**.
- Town officials are **Astynomoi**.
- Welfare works — wells, herbs, trees, hospitals — sit in **Rock Edict II**.
- The caravan chief of merchants is the **Sarthavaha** (*Arthashastra*).

> **Logic:** This is a **centralised** empire, not Gupta samanta-feudatory.

7.5 Important Mauryan Officials

Officer match-list | Kautilya names vs Greek names | do not swap pairs

Read this as **two machines**. Kautilya's *adhyakshas* are one picture. Megasthenes' boards are another. Do not mash them.

Revenue pair (first swap-trap)

- The **samaharta collects** all revenue.
- The **sannidhata stores** the *kosha* (treasury).
- Never reverse collector and storekeeper.

Land, justice, and tour officers

- The **rajuka** does land assessment and justice. Ashoka trusts them on tour.
- The **yukta** is a subordinate executive.
- The **pradeshika / pradeshtri** inspects the district and links police and spies.
- The **mahamatra** is a high officer of a province or department.
- The **dhamma-mahamatra** (धम्म महामात्र) appears in Rock Edict V. He works for welfare of sects, prisoners, and borders. Appointment is in the **14th year** after coronation.
- The **pativedaka** is the reporter. Rock Edict VI says the king is reachable always.
- The **gopa** and **sthanika** are Kautilya's rural circle officers.

Princes and forts

- The **kumara** is a prince-viceroy at **Taxila**, **Ujjain** (उज्जैन), or **Suvarnagiri**.
- **Tosali** is the Kalinga post.
- The **antapala** holds the frontier.
- The **durgapala** holds the fort.
- The **nagaraka / nagaradhyaksha** holds the city.

Department heads (*adhyakshas*)

- The **pautavadhyaksha** holds weights and measures.
- The **sitadhyaksha** holds crown agriculture.

- The **panyadhyaksha** holds trade.
- The **akshapataladhyaksha** holds accounts.
- The **akaradhyaksha** holds mines.
- The **lakshanadhyaksha** holds the mint.
- The **suradhyaksha** holds liquor.
- The **navadhyaksha** holds ships and the navy.
- The **hastyadhyaksha** holds elephants.
- The **ashvadhyaksha** holds horses.
- The **ayudhagaradhyaksha** holds the armoury.
- The **kupyadhyaksha** holds forest produce.
- The **sulkadhyaksha** holds customs.
- The **mudradhyaksha** holds passports and seals.
- The **sutradhyaksha** holds spinning and yarn.
- The **ganikadhyaksha** holds courtesans.
- The **sarthavaha** is the caravan / merchant-convoy chief.

Greek names (Megasthenes / Strabo)

- City officials in *Indica* are **Astynomoi**.
- Rural officers are **Agronomoi**.
- **Agronomai** work as **revenue / land** officers. That is the accepted key.
- Strabo also gives them roads and mile-pillars. That is the road trap, not the key.
- Weights are **not** Agronomai. Weights = *pautavadhyaksha*.

Road penalty

- *Pankodakasannirodhe* is the penalty for throwing dirt or causing mud and water to collect on roads.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2020, Q4

The official 'Agronomai' during Mauryan age was related with which of the following field?

A. Weight and measurement B. Administrative management C. Construction of roads D. Revenue management

Show answer

Ans: D. Strabo also makes them build roads and set mile-pillars — that is option **C**, the trap. The 2020 key is **revenue**. Weights = *pautavadhyaksha*.

> **Logic:** Samaharta ≠ Sannidhata. Agronomai ≠ roads in that paper.

7.6 Ashoka

Bindusara's son | Devanampiya Piyadassi | accession ~272 · coronation 268–232 BCE

Ashoka is the Mauryan emperor of the edicts. After the **Kalinga war** he turns from conquest by slaughter to **dhamma-vijaya**.

Family and early posts

- Mother in legends is **Subhadrangi / Dharma**.
- Viceroyship is first at **Taxila**, then at **Ujjain**.
- The *Ashokavadana* succession fight should be used lightly.
- Wife **Devi** of Vidisha is mother of **Mahinda** and **Sanghamitta**.
- Wife **Karuvaki** has the Queen's edict. Her son is **Tivala**.
- Wife **Tishyarakshita** belongs to the Bodhi-tree / Kunala legend.

Name on the stones

- Major edicts say **Piyadassi / Devanampiya**, not the personal name.
- The personal name **Ashoka** appears on Minor Rock Edicts at **Maski**, **Gujarra** (गुजर्रा), **Nittur**, and **Udegolam**.

Kalinga War (261 BCE) — Cause, Course, Result

Cause: Kalinga controlled the land and sea bridge between the Ganga valley and the Deccan / eastern seaboard. Independent Kalinga threatened Magadhan overseas and inland trade.

Course: In his **8th regnal year (~261 BCE)**, Ashoka invaded Kalinga. Rock Edict **XIII** remembers **1 lakh** killed, **1.5 lakh** deported, and countless sufferers.

Result: Kalinga was **annexed**; headquarters at **Tosali** and **Samapa**. Ashoka turned to **dhamma-vijaya**. Separate Kalinga edicts at **Dhauli** and **Jaugada** (जौगढ़) tell mahamatras that **"all men are my children."** He does **not** give Kalinga back.

After Kalinga

- In the **10th year** he makes a *dhammayatra* to Bodh Gaya (Rock Edict VIII), not a *viharayatra*.
- Rock Edict XIII names five western kings: **Antiochus II Theos**, **Ptolemy II Philadelphus**, **Antigonus Gonatas**, **Magas of Cyrene**, and **Alexander of Epirus**.
- The *Mahavamsa* missions follow the Third Council at Pataliputra under Moggaliputta Tissa.
- Mission lands include Kashmir–Gandhara, Mahishamandala, Vanavasi, Aparantaka, Maharatha, the Yona, the Himalaya, and **Suvannabhumi**.
- **Lanka** receives **Mahinda** and **Sanghamitta**, under king **Devanampiya Tissa**, with a Bodhi-sapling.
- Legend credits **84,000** stupas and viharas.
- **Jalauka** in Kashmir is from the *Rajatarangini* (राजतरंगिणी), not from edicts.
- The Barabar gift to Ajivikas is polished granite cells, not Buddhist viharas.
- Death is about **232 BCE**. The empire runs to **185 BCE**.

> **Logic:** Major edicts do **not** usually say the word “Ashoka.” Maski does.

7.6a Third Buddhist Council (Pataliputra)

c. 250 BCE | **Patron:** Ashoka | **President:** Moggaliputta Tissa | **Sources:** *Dipavamsa* and *Mahavamsa* (not Ashokan edicts)

- Ashoka convened the **Third Buddhist Council** at **Pataliputra** about **250 BCE**, after the Kalinga turn toward dhamma.
- Sinhalese tradition places it in Ashoka’s **17th–18th year** after coronation (coronation **268 BCE** → council near **250 BCE**).
- **Moggaliputta Tissa** presided. The council purified doctrine and organised missions.
- Missions went to Kashmir–Gandhara, Sri Lanka (**Mahinda**, **Sanghamitta**), and other regions.
- Council place order is **Rajagriha** (1st), then **Vaishali** (वैशाली) (2nd), then **Pataliputra** (3rd), then **Kundalvana** (4th).
- Third Council = **Ashoka** at **Pataliputra**. Fourth Council = **Kanishka** (कनिष्क) at **Kundalvana**.
- **Sri Lanka** received the mission but remained an **edge neighbour**, not a Mauryan province (RE II).

> **Logic:** The year **c. 250 BCE** comes from chronicle tradition. Ashokan edicts do **not** date the Third Council.

7.6b Ashoka's Dhamma Yatra Circuit

After Bodh Gaya visit | traditional pilgrimage order

- After turning toward Buddhism, Ashoka stopped hunting and began pilgrimage. Tradition places the circuit as **Lumbini** → **Kapilavastu** → **Bodh Gaya** → **Sarnath** → **Kushinagar** → **Shravasti**.
- **Rummindei** (रुम्मिनदेई) marks Lumbini (birth). **Bhabru / Bairat** shows him as **Piyadasi Raja of Magadha** and a Buddhist patron.
- **Sanchi** (सांची) is remembered as the finest / best-preserved early stupa core begun under Ashoka (Raisen, MP). **Bharhut** (भरहुत) railings bloom mainly in the **Shunga** (शुंग) age.

7.7 Ashoka's Dhamma

Ethical state policy for every community | after Kalinga | not a forced state religion

Ashoka’s **Dhamma** is a **public code of conduct**. It asks people of all sects to live with restraint and kindness. It is **not** “Buddhism made into the only state church.”

What Dhamma is

- Dhamma is **state ethic**. It covers kings, officers, householders, and border peoples.

- Ashoka personally favoured Buddhism and convened the Third Council. That personal faith is **separate** from the Dhamma he wrote on rocks and pillars for everyone.
- He never forces conversion. He asks for **tolerance** among sects.

How PE II defines Dhamma

- **Pillar Edict II** gives Ashoka's own short definition.
- It asks for **few sins** and **many virtues**.
- The virtues named are **compassion**, **liberality**, **truth**, and **purity**.
- This PE II list is the **edict definition** of Dhamma.
- That definition is **not** taken from the *Rahulovada* sutta.

The Bhabru / Rahulovada trap

- The **Bhabru** edict (also called **Calcutta-Bairat**) is a message to the **sangha**.
- In it Ashoka lists Buddhist texts for monks. One of them is ***Laghulovada*** (also called ***Rahulovada***).
- So Ashoka **knew** the sutta and valued it for monks.
- Knowing a sutta is **not** the same as defining state Dhamma from that sutta.
- UPPCS **2024** still treats this claim as **false**: "Ashoka's Dhamma definition is taken from *Rahulovada-sutta*."

Who spreads Dhamma — the dhamma-mahamatras

- Rock Edict **V** creates a new cadre called **dhamma-mahamatras** (धम्म महामात्र).
- They are appointed in Ashoka's **14th year** after coronation.
- Their beat covers **Brahmans**, **Shramanas**, **Ajivikas**, prisoners, border people, women, and slaves.
- Their job is moral welfare and concord, not collecting land revenue like a **rajuka** (रज्जुक).

From war-drum to dhamma-drum

- **Bherighosha** (भेरीघोष) means the **war-drum**.
- **Dhammaghosha** (धम्मघोष) means the **dhamma-drum**.
- Rock Edicts **IV** and **XIII** say the war-drum yields to the dhamma-drum.
- The image means moral conquest replaces conquest by slaughter.

Welfare written into Dhamma

- Rock Edict **II** records wells, shade trees, rest-houses, herbs, and hospitals.
- Care is for **men and beasts**. Veterinary care sits in this RE II fact.
- Rock Edict **I** cuts royal kitchen slaughter and limits *samajas* (समाज - festive gatherings).

Pluralism, not one sect only

- Ashoka still donates caves to **Ajivikas** at **Barabar**.
- Rock Edicts **III**, **VII**, and **XII** name **Brahmans** and **Shramanas** together.
- Rock Edict **XII** teaches **samavaya** (समवाय) — religious concord. It is not the Kalinga text (that is RE XIII).

The punchline of PE VII

- Pillar Edict **VII** says the **gift of dhamma is the best gift**.
- Material gifts matter less than teaching this ethic.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2024, Q20

Consider the following statements with respect to Ashoka:

1. The definition of Dhamma given by Ashoka is taken from "Rahulovada-sutta".
2. In the 14th year of his coronation, Ashoka appointed a new type of staff, called Dhamma-mahamatras.

A. Both 1 and 2 B. Neither 1 nor 2 C. Only 1 D. Only 2

Show answer

Logic: Tests whether state Dhamma is copied from *Rahulovada* (false) and whether dhamma-mahamatras in the **14th year** is true (true). Trap = treating Bhabru's monk-list as the PE II definition. **Ans: D — Only 2.** Statement 1 is false: PE II defines Dhamma; *Rahulovada* is only listed for monks at Bhabru. Statement 2 is true: RE V creates **dhamma-mahamatras** in the **14th year**.

> **Logic:** Dhamma ≠ forced conversion. Personal Buddhism ≠ state Dhamma. Bhabru lists texts; PE II defines Dhamma.

7.8 Major Rock Edicts

Fourteen uniform texts | site table is a separate match-list

RE	Fact
I	Ban/limit on slaughter and *samajas*; royal kitchen cut
II	Hospitals, herbs, wells; **Chola–Pandya–Satiyaputra–Keralaputra–Tamraparni** named
III	*Yukta, rajuka, pradeshika* tour **every 5 years**
IV	**Dhammaghosha** replaces bherighosha
V	**Dhamma-mahamatras** created
VI	King reachable at all times; *pativedakas*
VII	All sects may dwell everywhere
VIII	Dhamma-tours; Bodh Gaya (*sambodhi*)
IX	Useless rites vs true dhamma
X	Fame only through dhamma

RE	Fact
XI	*Dhamma-dana* (gift of dhamma)
XII	**Samavaya / religious synthesis** ←
XIII	**Kalinga**; five Greek kings (**Antioka** = Antiochus II Theos of Syria; **Turamaya** = Ptolemy II Philadelphus of Egypt; **Antikini** = Antigonus Gonatas of Macedonia; **Maka** = Magas of Cyrene; **Alikasudara** = Alexander of Epirus); dhamma-vijaya
XIV	Edicts written short or long as the place needs
Site	Region
------	--------
Girnar (Junagadh)	Gujarat
Kalsi	Dehradun, Uttarakhand
Dhauli	Odisha
Jaugada	Odisha
Shahbazgarhi	KP, Pakistan
Mansehra	KP, Pakistan
Sopara (शूर्पारक)	Maharashtra
Erragudi / Yerragudi	Andhra
Sannati (Kanaganahalli)	Karnataka

- **Separate Kalinga edicts** at Dhauli & Jaugada **replace RE XI–XIII**. To *mahamatras* of **Tosali** and **Samapa**. Line: **"All men are my children."**
- Kandahar bilingual (Greek + Aramaic) is a **frontier** edict, not one of the 14-site Brahmi set.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2022, Q54

Which of the following Rock Edicts of Ashoka speaks of religious synthesis?

A. Rock Edict XI B. Rock Edict XII C. Rock Edict XIII D. Rock Edict II

Show answer

Ans: B — XII. XIII = Kalinga. XI = dhamma as gift. II = welfare.

> **Logic:** Rock Edict **XII** = religious tolerance / synthesis. Rock Edict **XIII** = Kalinga.

7.9 Minor Rock Edicts

Personal voice | the name “Ashoka” | southern limit plus UP’s Ahraura

- The name **Ashoka** is spelled at **Maski** (Raichur), first found, then at **Gujarra** (Datia, MP), **Nittur**, and **Udegolam**.
- The Karnataka cluster marks the southern limit: Brahmagiri, Siddapura, Jatinga-Rameshwara, Gavimath, Palkigundu, Rajula-Mandagiri, Maski, Nittur, and Udegolam.
- Other Minor Rock sites include **Rupnath** and **Pangurariа** (MP), **Sahasram / Sasaram** (Bihar), **Bairat** (Rajasthan), and **Ahraura** in **Mirzapur, Uttar Pradesh**.
- The **Bhabru / Calcutta-Bairat** edict presents Ashoka as *upasaka*. It lists Vinaya-samukase, Aliya-vasani, Anagata-bhayani, Muni-gatha, Moneyasute, Upatisa-pasine, and **Laghulovada**.
- Bhabru lists **Laghulovada** among texts he valued. State Dhamma is still his **own edict-ethic**.
- Kandahar has a Greek Minor Rock Edict, a bilingual frontier text.
- **Kanaganahalli (Sannati)** has a sculpted panel labelled **Raya Asoka**, a rare named portrait.

> **Logic:** If the question is “where is the name Ashoka?” the answer is **Maski**, not Girnar.

7.10 Pillar Edicts

Seven major PE | Chunar sandstone | Mauryan polish | mostly Gangetic

PE	Fact
I	Self-check; little sin
II	**Defines dhamma** (compassion, liberality, truth, purity)
III	Deeds vs mere rites
IV	**Rajukas** independent justice; capital cases
V	Closed slaughter-days; **list of protected animals** (not dhamma-mahamatras — those are **RE V**)
VI	Inscriptions from the **12th** year onward
VII	Longest; “gift of dhamma is the best gift”; only on **Delhi-Topra** in full
Shaft	Place
---	---
Sarnath	Varanasi, UP
Sanchi	MP
Vaishali (Bakhira)	Bihar

PE	Fact
Sankissa	Farrukhabad belt
Lauriya-Nandangarh / Araraj	Bihar
Rampurva	Bihar
Rummindei	Lumbini, Nepal
Nigali Sagar	Nepal
Allahabad (इलाहाबाद)	from **Kaushambi**, UP
Delhi-Topra	from Topra, Haryana
Delhi-Meerut	from **Meerut, UP**

Minor pillar / schism: Sarnath, Sanchi, Kaushambi. The **Kaushambi schism edict** warns monks against splitting the sangha.

> **Logic:** National emblem lion capital = **Sarnath**. **Sanchi** is the great stupa complex.

7.11 Cave Architecture of Mauryan Period

Earliest Indian rock-cut | Barabar–Nagarjuni, Jehanabad, Bihar | granite polish

Cave	Hill	Patron	Fact
Sudama	Barabar	Ashoka, 12th year	Polished cell; Ajivika
Lomas Rishi	Barabar	(facade; no Ashokan text)	**Horseshoe chaitya-arch** — prototype of Bhaja/Karle/Ajanta fronts
Vishvakarma (Visva Zopri)	Barabar	Ashoka	Ajivika
Karan Chaupar	Barabar	Ashoka, 19th year	Rain-retreat for Ajivikas
Gopika, Vapiyaka, Vadathika	Nagarjuni	**Dasharatha**	Still **Ajivika** (आजीविक)

- These are **not** Buddhist viharas. Ajanta, Karle, and Bhaja copy the **horseshoe arch** centuries later.
- Palace memory is the **Kumrahar 80-pillar** hall at Pataliputra. Wooden palisade is Greek memory. Stone polish is the Ashokan trademark.
- Sculpture tagged Mauryan polish includes the **Didarganj Yakshi** (दीदारगंज यक्षी) at Patna (date debated).
- The **Parkham Yaksha** at Mathura is inscribed **Manibhadra**.
- Two Patna yakshas belong to the same polish tradition.

- The **Dhauli elephant** is another Mauryan sculpture fact.
- Barabar caves are **Mauryan** (Ashoka / Dasharatha gifts to Ajivikas). Dating them to the **6th century BCE** is false.

> **Logic:** Barabar ≠ Ajanta. Donee = **Ajivika**, not the sangha.

7.12 Kautilya's Arthashastra

Kautilya = Chanakya = Vishnugupta | 15 adhikaranas, about 150 chapters | recovered by R. Shamasastry in 1909

The *Arthashastra* is the Mauryan **statecraft handbook**. It is **not** the *Mudrarakshasa* and **not** Megasthenes' *Indica*.

Core toolkits

- The **four vidyas** (विद्या) are anvikshiki (आन्वीक्षिकी - philosophy), trayi (त्रयी - three Vedas), varta (वार्ता - agriculture/trade), and dandaniti (दण्डनीति - governance/law).
- The **saptanga** (सप्तांग) are swami (स्वामी - King), amatya (अमात्य - Minister), janapada (जनपद - Territory/People), durga (दुर्ग - Fort), kosha (कोष - Treasury), danda/bala (दण्ड/बल - Army), and **mitra** (मित्र - Ally, the **seventh** limb).
- The **four upayas** (उपाय) are sama (साम), dana (दान), bheda (भेद), and danda (दण्ड).
- The **shadgunya** (षाड्गुण्य - 6 foreign policies) are sandhi (संधि), vigraha (विग्रह), asana (आसन), yana (यान), samshraya (संश्रय), and dvaidhibhava (द्वैधीभाव).
- The **raja-mandala** (राजमण्डल) puts the *vijigishu* (विजिगीषु - would-be conqueror) at the centre, with ari, mitra, arimitra, and the rest of the twelve-king ring.
- Fort types are *audaka* (औदक - water fort), *parvata* (पर्वत / गिरिदुर्ग - mountain fort), *dhanvana* (धान्वन - desert fort), and *vanadurga* (वनदुर्ग - forest fort).

Posts and economy

- The **18 tirthas** (तीर्थ - highest officials) include mantrin (मन्त्रिन्), purohita (पुरोहित), senapati (सेनापति), yuvaraja (युवराज), dauvarika (दौवारिक), antarvamsika (अन्तर्वंशिक), prasasta (प्रशास्ता), samaharta (समाहर्ता), and sannidhata (सन्निधाता), plus pradeshta (प्रदेष्टा), nayaka (नायक), pauravyavaharika (पौरव्यावहारिक), karmantika (कार्मन्तिक), mantri-parishad-adhyaksha (मन्त्रिपरिषदाध्यक्ष), dandapala (दण्डपाल), durgapala (दुर्गपाल), antapala (अन्तपाल), and atavika (आटविक).
- The adhyaksha-state covers mines (*akaradhyaksha* / आकराध्यक्ष), salt (*lavanadhyaksha* / लवणाध्यक्ष), trade (*panyadhyaksha* / पण्याध्यक्ष), crown lands (*sitadhyaksha* / सीताध्यक्ष), forests, spinning, ships (*navadhyaksha* / नावाध्यक्ष), passports, and mint (*lakshanadhyaksha* / लक्षणाध्यक्ष).
- It is a **command economy**. Guilds (*shreni* (श्रेणी) / श्रेणी) are regulated, not abolished.

Slavery, courts, and family law

- **Slavery exists** here. That is a direct clash with Megasthenes' "no slaves."
- A person may become a slave by judicial punishment.

- If a female slave bears her master a son, she is set free (a common multi-statement stem).
- Courts: **Dharmasthiya** (धर्मस्थीय - civil) and **Kantakashodhana** (कण्टकशोधन - criminal / thorn-removal).
- Divorce is allowed in listed cases (desertion, long absence, barrenness, adultery).
- Contrast **Manusmriti**: a widower may remarry, but a widow is barred; foreigners who ignore local priestly custom are **fallen kshatriyas**.

Date and compare-text

- Date debate (Mauryan core versus later redaction) does not change the Prelims tag: it is the **Mauryan state-book**.
- The *Mudrarakshasa* is not this text.
- The book is often compared with Machiavelli's *Prince*.

> **Logic:** Kautilya is not Megasthenes. The Arthashastra is not the Indica.

7.13 Megasthenes

Seleucid envoy of Seleucus to Chandragupta | sat at Pataliputra (*Palibothra*)

- Did **not** march with Alexander. He arrives after the ~303 Seleucus treaty. *Indica* is lost. Quoted by Strabo, Arrian, Diodorus, Pliny, and Clement.
- Successor envoy **Deimachus** goes to Bindusara. Ptolemaic **Dionysius** is also named.
- Magadha in his vocabulary is **Prasii** (easterners). Capital is **Palibothra** at Ganga–Son.
- Howlers include gold-digging ants and Dionysus/Heracles as Indian culture-heroes. Useful bits are the palisade, the boards, and the seven classes.

> **Logic:** Megasthenes is not Nearchus and not Aristobulus.

7.14 Indica

Greek snapshot | mix of gold and howlers | two separate 'six boards'

- The seven classes are **not** varna. They run: philosophers (**Brahman and Shramana**), farmers, herdsmen and hunters, artisans, soldiers, overseers (*ephoroi*), and councillors (the smallest class).
- The city has six boards of five: crafts, foreigners, **births and deaths**, trade, manufactures, and sales-tax / tithe. Birth–death registration is the municipal function that still continues today.
- The army has six boards of five: navy, transport/bullock, infantry, cavalry, chariots, and elephants.
- Pataliputra has a wooden palisade, a moat, **570 towers**, and **64 gates**. Town officials are **Astynomoi**.
- The claim of **no slavery** clashes with the Arthashastra.
- The text also claims **no usury**.

- It claims farmers are spared in war.
- It claims the king never sleeps twice in the same room.
- It claims women among palace guards.
- Sales-tax evasion in the Greek account can carry the **death** penalty.
- **Agronomoi** work in the countryside as **revenue / land** officers.
- Strabo also gives them **roads and mile-pillars**. That is option C, the trap.
- The *Indica* does **not** name Chanakya or the *Arthashastra*.

> **Logic:** The seven-caste list is **Indica**, not Manu. Philosophers = Brahmins + Shramanas.

7.15 Provincial Administration

Five viceroyalties | kumara / aryaputra | ahara below

Province	HQ	Governor
Prachyapatha / Magadha core	**Pataliputra**	King
Uttarapatha	**Taxila**	Kumara
Avantiratha / Avantirashtra	**Ujjain**	Kumara
Kalinga (after 261)	**Tosali** (+ **Samapa**)	Kumara / mahamatra
Dakshinapatha (दक्षिणापथ)	**Suvarnagiri**	Kumara

- Stack: empire → province → **ahara / vishaya** → *sthanika* circle → *gopa* (5–10 villages) → *grama* (*gramika*).
- Edicts also say **aryaputra** for princes. Mahamatras can hold a province when no prince is posted.
- Post-Ashoka Jain memory: **Dasharatha** east, **Samprati** west/south — partition story, not an edict.
- Pataliputra is the **capital**, not "a province." Eastern UP (Kashi–Kosala–Vatsa) sits in the core, not a fifth kumara-seat.
- **Taxila** was also the most famous learning centre of the Mauryan age.

7.16 Revenue Administration

7.16 Revenue Administration

Land revenue is the main tank | Samaharta collects | Sannidhata stores

The Mauryan state lives mainly on land dues. Hold the levy names as separate facts.

Levy	Fact
Bhaga	Produce share; Arthashastra **1/6** (*shadbhaga*)
Bali	Extra / religious levy; **Rummindei drops it**
Hiranya	Cash
Shulka	Toll / customs (*sulkadhyaksha*)
Vishti (विष्टि -)	Forced labour
Udakabhaga	Irrigation cess
Pranaya	Emergency / benevolence tax (**UKPCS 2021**)
Sita	Crown-farm produce (*sitadhyaksha*)
Vivit	Pasture tax (*vivitadhyaksha*)

- Mines, salt, liquor, forest (*kupya*), and guild dues also feed the treasury.
- Punch-marked silver sits in the *kosha*.
- At Rummindei (Lumbini), **bali** is remitted and *bhaga* is cut to **1/8**.
- Agronomai measure fields for this revenue machine. That is the accepted key.
- The *pautavadhyaksha* is the **weights** officer. He is not Agronomai.
- Mauryas did **not** grant land on a religious basis as a system.
- The earliest epigraphic religious land grants appear under the **Satavahanas**.
- **Sohgaura** copper plate (Gorakhpur, UP) and **Mahasthan** inscription (Bangladesh) are the earliest royal orders to store grain for famine relief.
- At Girnar / Sudarshana, **Pushyagupta** under Chandragupta built the lake.
- **Tushaspha** under Ashoka cut canals.
- **Rudradaman** later repaired it (full story in Topic 8).

> **Logic:** Rummindei = tax-cut at Lumbini, not a new capital. **Pranaya** = emergency tax.

7.16a Mauryan Trade and Economy

Trade beside land tax | neighbours stay neighbours | urban markers

- Land revenue (**bhaga**, **bali**, **hiranya**) was the main tank.
- The **samaharta** collected. The **sannidhata** stored.
- **Guilds (*shreni*)** were regulated, not abolished.
- Craft towns continued under *panyadhyaksha* control.
- Rock Edict **II** names **Chola, Pandya, Satiyaputra, Keralaputra, and Tamraparni** as neighbours — not Mauryan provinces.
- The northwest had **Yavana** (यवन) contact.

- Punch-marked **silver** (रूपक) remained the standard coin.
- **Ring-wells** and **NBPW** mark urban Mauryan sites.

7.17 Spy System

Kautilya's secret service | sanstha = stationary | sanchara = mobile

Ashoka did **not** abolish spies. The spy chapter belongs to the *Arthashastra*, not to Rock Edict XII.

Stationary covers (*sanstha*)

- *Kapatika* is the student cover.
- *Udasthita* is the renouncer cover.
- *Grihapatika* is the householder cover.
- *Vaidehaka* is the trader cover.
- *Tapasa* is the ascetic cover.

Mobile covers (*sanchara*)

- *Satri* is one mobile type.
- *Tikshna* is another.
- *Rasada* is the poisoner.
- *Bhikshuki* is the wandering nun.
- Female agents exist in the system.

Other spy facts

- **Ubhayavetana** is a double agent, paid by both sides.
- The *vishkanya* is later legend, not an edict.
- **Upadha** tests of ministers use dharma, artha, kama, and bhaya.
- The *pradeshtri* inspects and feeds intelligence.
- The Ashokan face is the *pativedaka* of Rock Edict VI.
- Megasthenes' *ephoroi* are an outsider's overseers.
- The king gets secret reports **outside** the normal chain so officers cannot collude.

> **Logic:** Spy chapters are **Arthashastra**, not Rock Edict XII. Ashoka did not "abolish spies."

UP Focus

Fact	Place
Ahraura MRE	**Mirzapur** (मिर्ज़ापुर) — UP's own Minor Rock Edict

Fact	Place
Sarnath pillar / four-lion capital	Varanasi — **national emblem**
Schism edict	Sarnath + **Kaushambi**
Allahabad pillar	Originally **Kaushambi**; now Prayagraj (Ashoka + Gupta + Jahangir)
Meerut pillar	Origin **Meerut** (मेरठ); Firoz Shah moved it to Delhi
Sankissa elephant capital	Farrukhabad belt
Kashi–Kosala–Vatsa	Inside the **imperial core**, not a kumara-province
Kushinagar	Mauryan-period Buddhist site (Malla); not an edict site
Birth story	Magadha / Moriya; **not** “Ashoka of UP”